

consumption at eight litres per capita followed by Punjab's 7.9 litres. This is much above the national average which according to a WHO study is less than two litres, making India's rank a low 150th in the world in liquor consumption. The world average, however, is five litres. India's low per capita consumption is said to be owing to its huge population as it is one of the world's largest producers of liquor (2,300 million litre annually) and leads in consumption in South Asia, according to the Alcohol Atlas of India.

While 15-20 per cent of the popu-

certainly rank third in the list. "It is quite shocking. Despite all efforts to spread awareness against liquor consumption, it has been rising alarmingly," says Minister for Excise P.K. Gurudasan.

The rise in consumption is also a matter of concern for poet and anti-alcohol activist B. Sugathakumari who says, "Kerala may be a paradise for tipplers but it is a hell for its victims." She holds the state and political parties responsible for binge drinking in Kerala. The bankrupt Government encourages the liquor industry which is its only cash cow. The

road accidents but other social problems like suicides, divorces and domestic violence. More than 4,000 people die every year in road accidents in Kerala. The state also has the country's highest suicide rate at 28 per lakh population as against the national average of 11.2, highest incidence of mental illnesses at 272 per lakh population as against the national average of 105, highest incidence of domestic violence and also one of the highest divorce rates in the country. "About 30 per cent of the attempted suicides in the state are of spouses of alcoholics," says Dr C.J.

Photographs by C SHANKAR



“Kerala may be a paradise for tipplers but it is a hell for its victims.”

B. SUGATHAKUMARI,
Poet and social activist



KERALITES GULPED IMFL WORTH RS 154.44 CRORE DURING THE ONAM FESTIVAL

lation consumes liquor in the country, the figure for Kerala is 30 per cent, says the A.P. Udayabhanu Commission which probed the state's alcohol consumption trends. According to ADIC, the average age of starting consumption of liquor was 19 years in 1986 but it fell to less than 13 in 2001. A recent study by the Kerala Sastra Sahitya Parishad, an NGO, says Keralites collectively spend most on marriages (Rs 6,787 crore annually), followed by medical treatment (Rs 2,800 crore). Clearly, spending on liquor, officially on IMFL alone, would

contribution of IMFL sales to the state exchequer has gone up from Rs 1,312 crore in 2001-02 to more than Rs 3,000 crore last year, 25 per cent of the state's total tax revenue. It gets an additional Rs 150 crore annually from auctioning 5,000-odd toddy shops. Kerala Catholic Bishops' Council Chairman Archbishop Daniel Acharuparampil says, "The state Government wants to maximise revenue from this social vice."

Many experts believe that the state's addiction to the bottle is the root cause not just for its increasing

John, psychiatrist and founder of Maithri, a suicide counselling centre.

The major reason for the rise in consumption of alcohol is the huge increase in disposable incomes caused by rise in the flow of remittances from abroad. More than 20 lakh Keralites are settled abroad, mainly in the Gulf, whose collective remittances have now touched almost Rs 40,000 crore annually, thrice the state's total tax revenue. Money and liquor may given the state a new high, but both together can plummet it to new lows.